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Plantation slavery was more

than just a system of labour and a distinct mode of racial domination. Whether it encapsulates the inner essence of capitalism or was a vestigial, essentially precapitalist element in a dependant relationship to capitalism proper, it provided the foundations for a distinctive network of economic, social, and political relations. Above all, "its demise threw open the most fundamental questions of economy, society and polity,"³⁵ and it has retained a central place in the historical memories of the black Atlantic.

The way these populations continue to make creative, communicative use of the memory of slavery points constructively away from the twin positions that have overdetermined the debate on modernity so far—an uncritical and complacent rationalism and a self-conscious and rhetorical anti-humanism which simply trivialises the potency of the negative. Moving beyond these options requires consideration of what, following Walter Benjamin, can be called the primal history of modernity.³⁶ Although Benjamin was not attuned to the possibility that modern history could be seen as fractured along the axis that separates European masters and mistresses from their African slaves, there are elements of his thinking, particularly those which derive from his relationship to Jewish mysticism, which make it a valuable resource for my own critique.³⁷ The time has come for the primal history of modernity to be reconstructed from the slaves' points of view. These emerge in the especially acute consciousness of both life and freedom which is nurtured by the slave's "mortal terror of his sovereign master" and the continuing "trial by death" which slavery becomes for the male slave.³⁸ This primal history offers a unique perspective on many of the key intellectual and political issues in the modernity debates. I have already mentioned the idea of history as progress. Apart from that thorny perennial, the slaves' perspectives require a discrete view not just of the dynamics of power and domination in plantation societies dedicated to the pursuit of commercial profit but of such central categories of the Enlightenment project as the idea of universality, the fixity of meaning, the coherence of the subject, and, of course, the foundational ethnocentrism in which these have all tended to be anchored. Each of these issues has an impact on the formation of racial discourse and a relevance in understanding the development of racial politics. These problems aside, the slaves' perspectives necessitate a critical stance on the discourse of bourgeois humanism which several scholars have implicated in the rise and consolidation of scientific racism.³⁹ Using the memory of slavery as an interpretive device suggests that this humanism cannot simply be repaired by introducing the figures of black folks who had previously been confined to the intermediate category between animal and human that Du Bois identifies as a "*tertium quid*."⁴⁰

In keeping with the spiritual components which also help to distinguish

them from modern secular rationality, the slaves' perspectives deal only secondarily in the idea of a rationally pursued utopia. Their primary categories are steeped in the idea of a revolutionary or eschatological apocalypse—the Jubilee. They provocatively suggest that many of the advances of modernity are in fact insubstantial or pseudo-advances contingent on the power of the racially dominant grouping and that, as a result, the critique of modernity cannot be satisfactorily completed from within its own philosophical and political norms, that is, immanently. The representative figures whose work I shall explore below were all acutely aware of the promise and potential of the modern world. Nevertheless, their critical perspectives on it were only partly grounded in its own norms. However uneasily their work balanced its defences of modernity against its critiques, they drew deliberately and self-consciously on premodern images and symbols that gain an extra power in proportion to the brute facts of modern slavery. These have contributed to the formation of a vernacular variety of unhappy consciousness which demands that we rethink the meanings of rationality, autonomy, reflection, subjectivity, and power in the light of an extended meditation both on the condition of the slaves and on the suggestion that racial terror is not merely compatible with occidental rationality but cheerfully complicit with it. In terms of contemporary politics and social theory, the value of this project lies in its promise to uncover both an ethics of freedom to set alongside modernity's ethics of law and the new conceptions of selfhood and individuation that are waiting to be constructed from the slaves' standpoint—forever disassociated from the psychological and epistemic correlates of racial subordination. This unstable standpoint is to be understood in a different way from the clarion calls to epistemological narcissism and the absolute sovereignty of unmediated experience⁴¹ which sometimes appear in association with the term. It can be summed up in Foucault's tentative extension of the idea of a *critical* self-inventory into the political field. This is made significantly in a commentary upon the Enlightenment: "The critical ontology of ourselves has to be considered not, certainly, as a theory, a doctrine, nor even as a permanent body of knowledge that is accumulating; it has to be conceived as an attitude, an ethos, a philosophical life in which the critique of what we are is at one and the same time the historical analysis of the limits that are imposed on us and an experiment with the possibility of going beyond them."⁴²

26. Patricia Hill Collins, *Black Feminist Thought: Knowledge, Consciousness and the Politics of Empowerment* (New York and London: Routledge, 1991), p. 27. The deconstructive zeal with which Hill Collins urges her readers to take traditional epistemological assumptions apart is exhausted after tackling "woman" and "intellectual." It runs out long before she reaches the key words "black" and "Afrocentric," which appear to be immune to this critical operation (see p. 17).

27. Ibid., p. 40.

28. Ibid., pp. 32-33.

29. Ibid., p. 23.

30. Jane Flax, *Thinking Fragments* (Berkeley and Oxford: University of California Press, 1990).

31. Trans. J. B. Baillie (New York: Harper and Row, 1967), ch. 4.

32. Cornel West, "The Religious Foundations of the Thought of Martin Luther King, Jr.," in *We Shall Overcome: Martin Luther King and the Black Freedom Struggle*, ed. Peter J. Albert and Ronald Hoffman (New York: Pantheon, 1990).

33. Quoted by Kimberley Benston in *Baraka* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1976), p. 90. For a discussion of the relationship between Baraka and Hegel see Esther M. Jackson, "LeRoi Jones (Imamu Amiri Baraka): Form and the Progression of Consciousness," in Kimberly W. Benston, ed., *Imamu Amiri Baraka (LeRoi Jones): Twentieth Century Views* (Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice Hall, 1978).

34. *Being and Nothingness* (London: Methuen 1969), bk. 1, pp. 157-158.

35. Eric Foner, *Nothing but Freedom* (Baton Rouge and London: Louisiana State University Press, 1983), p. 1.

36. Walter Benjamin, "Paris: The Capital of the Nineteenth Century," in *Charles Baudelaire: A Lyric Poet in the Era of High Capitalism* (London: Verso, 1976), p. 159. See also Richard Wolin, *Walter Benjamin: An Aesthetic of Redemption* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1982).

37. Andrew Benjamin, "Tradition and Experience," in Andrew Benjamin, ed., *The Problems of Modernity* (London: Routledge, 1989).

38. See Orlando Patterson's discussion of Hegel in *Slavery and Social Death* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1982), pp. 97-101.

39. Dominique Lecourt, "On Marxism as a Critique of Sociological Theories," in M. O'Callaghan, ed., *Sociological Theories: Race and Colonialism* (Paris: UNESCO, 1980), p. 267.

40. "... somewhere between men and cattle God had created a tertium quid, and called it Negro,—a clownish, simple creature, at times lovable within its limitations, but straitly foreordained to walk within the Veil." *The Souls of Black Folk* (1903; New York: Bantam, 1989), p. 63.

41. For a critique of these appeals see Joan Wallach Scott, "The Evidence of Experience," *Critical Inquiry* 17 (Summer 1991): 773-797.

42. Michel Foucault, "What Is Enlightenment?" in *The Foucault Reader*, ed. Paul Rabinow (Harmondsworth: Peregrine, 1986), p. 50.

43. George Shepperson, "Frederick Douglass and Scotland," *Journal of Negro History* 38, no. 3 (1953): 307-321.

44. Waldo E. Martin, *The Mind of Frederick Douglass* (Durham and London: University of North Carolina Press, 1984); L. Litwack and A. Meier, *Black Leaders of the Nineteenth Century* (Urbana and Chicago: University of Illinois Press, 1988);